MARKET MIND

Understand before you move.

LAUNCH BEFORE YOU STOCK.

A practical market-validation system for first-time consumer-product founders

HEALTHY-FOOD EDITION

CASE STUDY: KORA

THE 5-GATE VALIDATION SYSTEM



Manel Krichene

Founder & CEO, MARKET MIND

First edition, 2026

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MARKET MIND: LAUNCH BEFORE YOU STOCK
A practical market-validation system for first-time consumer-product founders
First edition, 2026

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READ THIS FIRST

How to Use This Book

This is a working book. Every chapter ends with a decision and an output for your Validation File. If you finish the book without filling in the tools, you have read it. You have not validated anything.

What every chapter gives you

Block	What it is
The Decision	One question you must be able to answer when the chapter ends.
The Method	Numbered steps, with the time and money each step needs.
The Tool	A ready-to-use template printed in the book. Print the tool pages or copy them into a notebook. No spreadsheet is needed.
The Kora Example	The running case: a fictional healthy-snack brand taken through every step with real arithmetic.
The Traps	Mistakes first-time food founders make at this step, and the counter-move.
The Output	The deliverable that goes into your Validation File.

Pick your path

Path	Time	What you do	Test budget*
7-Day Sprint A fast read before you invest more time	7 days	Chapters 1–4, 8 and 10. Skip the paid tests and run the lowest-cost version of each step.	$0 track
30-Day System Recommended	30 days	All chapters in order, following the week-by-week plan in Appendix A.	About $300
Deep Dive You are about to commit savings or outside money	30–45 days	Everything, plus paid ad tests, in-person tastings, co-packer negotiation and pilot-batch planning.	$1,500 or more

**Budget tracks are defined in Chapter 8. Chapters 1 and 2 are mandatory on every path. The Kora case study follows the Deep Dive, because physical food samples cost more to produce than samples of most other products.*

Set up your Validation File

Open one folder, paper or digital, before you start. Every output in this book goes into it, in this order:

Section	Contents	Built in
00 · Limits	First-Order Exposure Table, Risk Cap, time cap	Chapter 1
01 · The Bet	Niche Test, Launch Bet Canvas, hypotheses, signed thresholds, kill criteria, compliance flags	Chapter 2
02 · Market	Market scan, review coding, price bands, unit economics	Chapters 3–4
03 · Customers	Interview notes, language bank, survey results	Chapters 5–6
04 · Offer	Positioning statement, message angles, landing-page copy	Chapter 7
05 · Tests	Test plans, raw results, results against thresholds	Chapter 8

Section	Contents	Built in
06 · Supply	Co-packer comparison, spec sheet, sample scorecard	Chapter 9
07 · Verdict	Scorecard, signed decision memo, batch plan	Chapters 10–11

Date every page. Keep raw material, not just summaries: screenshots, notes, and recordings made with consent. In Chapter 10 you will defend your verdict to another person. The file is your evidence.

Conventions

- **Gates 1–5** are the five stages of the system. **Levels 1–5** are the signal-strength ladder (Chapter 1). Do not confuse them.
- **Illustrative** numbers are examples. Replace them with your own. They are never benchmarks.
- Amounts are in US dollars. Use your own currency and your own prices.
- **What you need:** a printer or a notebook, a phone for interviews (record only with consent), a free landing-page and form tool (options in Appendix H), and eight to ten hours a week.

THE FIRST ORDER IS YOUR BIGGEST BET

Introduction

Most first-time product founders do things in the wrong order. They perfect the recipe, design the packaging, find a co-packer and place the order. Only then do they find out whether anyone wants it.

By then the money is in boxes. **In food, the boxes have a date printed on them.**

A first production run of a few thousand units is often the largest check a new founder will ever write. It is usually placed on the strength of three things: enthusiasm from friends and family, a competitor's success, and a hunch. None of them is evidence that a stranger will pay for your product.

This book reverses the order. You will test demand first, with real people and small, controlled costs. You will place a production order only when the evidence justifies it and the downside is capped in advance.

Why healthy food

Healthy food is one of the most attractive and most punishing categories for a first-time founder.

Why it attracts founders	Why it punishes them
People care about what they eat. A small batch can be made cheaply. Trends are easy to see.	Shelves and feeds are crowded. Taste is personal. Claims are regulated. Products expire. Margins are thin, and reaching a customer costs more than most founders expect.

Each of these makes validation more valuable. The method works for any physical consumer product, but every example, tool and compliance note in this book is written for healthy food.

Market evidence and mind evidence

Data alone will not tell you why a shopper hesitates over a $4 pouch. Intuition alone will not tell you that most of your potential customers cannot be reached at a profitable cost. The system uses both:

- **Market evidence:** size, competition, prices, economics, channels.
- **Mind evidence:** why people buy, what they distrust, what they would switch from, and what they will actually pay for.

This is the thinking behind MARKET MIND, applied to one painful problem: knowing whether to place the first order.

What you will have on Day 30

- A **Risk Cap** and a time cap, written before you spend anything.
- A one-page **bet** with thresholds you set in advance and criteria that tell you when to stop.
- Evidence from **10 to 15 real conversations** with people who match your customer.
- A price range grounded in **behavior**, not opinion.
- Results from **demand tests** in which people took a costly action.
- A scored, signed **Go, Iterate or Kill** decision. If Go, a pilot batch sized by evidence.

Sometimes the decision will be Go. Often it will be “change this first.” Occasionally it will be Stop, which is the cheapest outcome you could have bought.

Who this book is for, and who it is not

This book is for	This book is not for
First-time founders of a physical healthy-food or better-for-you product: snacks, drinks, pantry goods, ready-to-eat items.	Software or app founders.
Founders who have not yet placed a first production order.	Established brands with sales history.
Founders willing to talk to 15 strangers.	Products intended to treat or prevent medical conditions.
	Anyone looking for a guarantee of success.

Understand before you move.

Manel Krichene
Founder & CEO, MARKET MIND

PART I

FOUNDATIONS

Decide what you are testing, what you are risking, and what would make you stop.

Part I contains no tests. It makes tests meaningful. Most founders skip it, run a few experiments, and then read the results however they like. You will do the opposite: set the limits first.

1	**The Inventory Trap**	Why first orders lose money, how food adds three clocks, how the 5-Gate System and the signal ladder work, and how to cap your loss before you begin. **You leave with:** First-Order Exposure Table · Risk Cap · time cap
2	**Define the Bet**	How to choose a niche customer, write a one-page bet, turn assumptions into testable hypotheses, pre-register your thresholds and write kill criteria. **You leave with:** Niche Test · Launch Bet Canvas · Assumption Ranking · Pre-Registration Page · Kill Criteria Card · Compliance Flag Sheet

Validation is a decision system, not a research project.

CHAPTER

1 THE INVENTORY TRAP

THE DECISION

Nothing gets produced until demand is proven. Set the maximum amount you are willing to lose before you start.

1.1 The wrong order, and the right one

The default path for a first-time founder runs from product to market: perfect the product, produce it, then look for customers. Every step spends money that cannot be recovered if the last step fails. The validated path runs the other way. It spends small amounts on evidence first and lets the evidence decide how much to produce.

THE USUAL PATH: PRODUCT FIRST



Almost the whole first-order budget is spent before the first real evidence arrives.

THE VALIDATED PATH: EVIDENCE FIRST



Only the Validation Budget is spent before the verdict. The batch is sized by what you learn.

1.2 Anatomy of a first-order loss

A supplier's quote answers one question: what does the product cost? Your question is different: **how much money must I commit before I know whether this works?** The gap between the two is where first orders fail.

KORA · FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE

Meet Kora. Lena, 34, worked six years in hospital logistics and noticed that her night-shift colleagues lived on vending-machine snacks. She developed **Kora**: a shelf-stable, savory snack of roasted lentils, seeds and herbs with no added sugar, in a pouch that opens with one hand. Retail price: **$24 for a box of six 60 g pouches** ($4.00 per pouch).

A co-packer quotes **$1.40 per pouch** for a minimum run of **3,000 pouches**. "The quote is $4,200," Lena tells her partner. "That is affordable." Here is what the quote actually commits her to.

Cost item	Amount	Paid when
A · BEFORE PRODUCTION		
Recipe samples, three rounds	$450	Before ordering
Nutrition analysis and shelf-life check	$900	Before ordering
Label and pouch design	$600	Before ordering
Product liability insurance, year one	$750	Before ordering
B · PRODUCTION		
Co-packer run: 3,000 pouches × $1.40 **(the quote)**	$4,200	Deposit at order, balance before shipping
Pouches and printed labels (packaging minimum)	$900	At order
C · AFTER PRODUCTION		
Inbound freight to storage	$350	On delivery
Storage, three months	$300	Monthly
D · LAUNCH ASSETS		
Website and product photography	$800	Before launch
E · SELLING IT		
Ads to reach 500 customers at an **assumed** $22 each	$11,000	During sell-through
TOTAL EXPOSURE	**$20,250**	
Revenue if all 500 boxes sell at $24 (before shipping, fees, returns)	$12,000	



$2,700 Before production
$4,200 Co-packer quote
$900 Packaging
$1,450 Freight, storage, launch assets
$11,000 Ads to sell it through

Total exposure: $20,250. Percentages are rounded. All figures are illustrative.

The $4,200 quote is **21%** of the real exposure. **54%** of it is ad spend that appears on no supplier invoice. The $22 per customer is an assumption, and Chapter 8 replaces it with a measured number. Even a complete sell-out returns $12,000 against $20,250 out the door. That is not a reason to quit, because repeat purchases and better ad efficiency change the picture. It is a reason to know the number **before** you order.

Five ways a first order loses money, and the gate that catches each

How the order fails	Kora version	Caught at
The market is not worth entering	Savory snacks are crowded and ad costs are higher than assumed	Gate 1 · Observe
The problem is not real or painful	Night-shift staff are happy with their vending machine	Gate 2 · Interpret
The offer is wrong	Right customer, but a six-box at $24 is the wrong pack or price	Gate 3 · Identify
People will not take a costly action	Plenty of likes, almost no preorders	Gate 4 · Strategize
Right product, wrong quantity	3,000 pouches ordered, 1,500 still in storage at month six	Gate 5 · Move

1.3 Food adds three clocks

Most products sit in a warehouse patiently. Food does not. Three clocks start the moment you place the order.

Clock	What starts it	What it costs you	Counter-move
Shelf life	Production date. Every week removes sellable time.	Stock you can only discount or discard. Many retailers and distributors require a minimum remaining shelf life on delivery, so stock can become unsellable before it expires. Check each buyer's rule.	Order the smallest viable batch. Replenish in stages. Plan sell-through before you order.
Cash	Deposit to the co-packer.	Money leaves weeks before it returns: samples, order, packaging lead time, production, freight, storage, first sale, payout. Illustrative Kora timeline: first sale about nine weeks after the order.	Map the timeline before you order. Know the week when your cash is lowest.
Compliance	Packaging print run.	Once pouches are printed, any change to claims, ingredients or allergen statements means reprinting, relabeling or scrapping. A regulatory problem can stop sales entirely.	Write the claim list first (Chapter 2). Use stickers or short print runs for the pilot.

KORA · STRESS TEST

Half-plan stress test. Suppose Kora sells 250 boxes instead of 500. 1,500 pouches, about $2,550 of product and packaging cost, are now in storage with the shelf-life clock running, and the price on those pouches only goes one way.

1.4 Research, testing and validation are three different jobs

	Research	Testing	Validation
Question	What is happening, and why?	Does version A beat version B?	Should I commit money to this?
Output	Understanding	A measurement of one variable	A decision: Go, Iterate or Kill
Kora example	Interview 12 night-shift staff about their breaks	Run two ad angles against each other	Combine everything against thresholds you set in advance
How it fails	Endless research, no decision	Polishing details of an unvalidated idea	Deciding on opinions instead of behavior

This book uses research and testing as inputs. Validation is the discipline that connects them to a decision.

1.5 The 5-Gate Validation System

The rest of the book follows five gates. Each one asks a single question, collects a specific kind of evidence, and produces an output. Gates 1 and 2 collect market evidence and mind evidence. Gates 3 to 5 combine them into an offer, a test and a verdict.

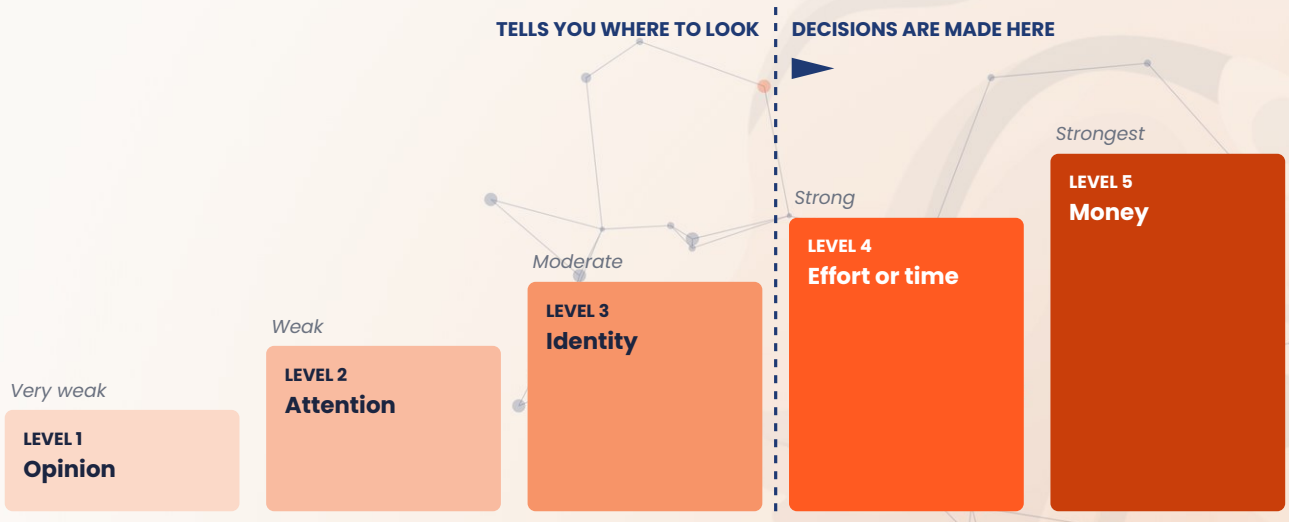
GATE 1 OBSERVE	GATE 2 INTERPRET	GATE 3 IDENTIFY	GATE 4 STRATEGIZE	GATE 5 MOVE
Is there a market worth entering? **Ch. 3–4**	Do real people have this problem, and how do they talk about it? **Ch. 5–6**	What exactly do we offer, to whom, at what price? **Ch. 7**	Will people take a costly action? **Ch. 8–9**	What does the evidence say, and how much do we order? **Ch. 10–11**

Gate	You gather	Output	Chapters
1 · Observe	Market scan, price bands, review mining, unit economics	Market Scan Sheet, maximum customer cost	3–4
2 · Interpret	Customer interviews, short survey, willingness to pay	Problem-intensity score, Language Bank, price range	5–6
3 · Identify	Positioning, offer, message angles	Positioning statement, three testable angles	7
4 · Strategize	Demand tests, samples, co-packer checks	Results against pre-registered thresholds	8–9
5 · Move	Scorecard, batch-sizing math	Signed decision memo, pilot-batch plan	10–11

You can fail at any gate. Failing early is the system working.

1.6 The signal-strength ladder

Not all evidence is equal. "I love it" costs the speaker nothing. A preorder costs them money. The ladder ranks every signal in this book by what it cost the person who gave it.



Level	Signal	Kora example	What it proves
1 · Opinion	"Great idea." A "yes" on "would you buy this?"	A friend finishes a sample and says it is delicious	That people are polite

Level	Signal	Kora example	What it proves
2 · Attention	Clicks, video views, saves, comments	A post about night-shift snacking gets 300 saves	Curiosity
3 · Identity	An email or WhatsApp sign-up that includes a qualifying answer	A nurse joins the waitlist and states her shift pattern	Interest from the right person, who spent a minute
4 · Effort or time	A booked call, a long form, a sample request that takes work	A ward manager books a 20-minute call and fills in a 12-question form	They paid in time
5 · Money	Refundable deposit, preorder, paid sample, a purchase at a tasting	A nurse pays $4 for a pouch after a tasting	They paid in money

Decisions are made on Level 4 and 5 evidence. Levels 1 to 3 only tell you where to look.

Two adjustments for food. (1) "Delicious" is the most generous word in the food business. It is free and polite, so file it under Level 1. What counts is behavior: do they finish the pouch, ask where to buy it, or pay for it? (2) Count signals from people who do not match your target customer as Level 1, whatever they do. A preorder from your sister is still Level 1.

1.7 Three outcomes: Go, Iterate, Kill

Verdict	Meaning	What you do next
GO	Evidence meets your pre-registered thresholds and there is no fatal flaw.	Order a pilot batch, never above the ceiling you set in your Risk Cap.
ITERATE	Promising, but one specific dimension fails: problem, price, audience, angle, offer or product.	Change one thing, retest inside your iteration reserve. **Maximum two Iterate cycles.** A third means you are avoiding a Kill.
KILL	Below the kill line, or a fatal flaw: economics, safety, compliance or quality.	Stop. Write down what you learned. Keep the money. Start a new bet if you wish.

Why Kill is a success. Kora's validation budget is $1,500. The money committed before the first sale, excluding ads, is $9,250. Killing at validation costs about **one-sixth** of killing after production, before counting unsold stock. A Kill at Gate 2 is the cheapest lesson you will ever buy.

1.8 Traps: five biases that vote to skip validation

Bias	How it sounds	Counter-move
Friends-and-family approval	"Everyone who tried it loved it."	File their feedback under Level 1. Test strangers who match your target.
Founder palate	"I would eat this every day."	You are one palate, not a market. Run blind tastings with target customers against a competitor product.
Survivorship	"Brand X did it, so can I."	You see the survivors, not the failures. Read Brand X's 3-star reviews and ask how long they took and what they spent.
Trend bias	"Healthy snacking is booming."	A growing category is not demand for your product. Test your niche, not the trend.
Sunk cost	"I have already paid for the samples and the design."	Money spent is gone either way. Judge only future spending, and write kill criteria in advance (Chapter 2).

1.9 Tool: your Risk Cap

The Risk Cap is the maximum amount of money you can lose on this project without damaging your life or your ability to try again. It is decided now, calmly, before any test produces a number that tempts you.

1. Complete the **First-Order Exposure Table** (Tool 1.1, page 16) using your own co-packer quote. Include ad spend.
2. Complete the **Risk Cap worksheet** (Tool 1.2, page 17). It subtracts your emergency reserve and planned obligations from your savings.
3. Split the cap into three buckets: a **Validation Budget** (10% as a starting point), an **Iteration Reserve** (10%) and a **Pilot-Batch Ceiling** (the rest).
4. Compare your planned first order to the ceiling. If it does not fit, the plan changes. The cap does not.
5. Set a **time cap**: how many days and hours per week you will give validation. Write it down. Then sign and date the page.

KORA · RESULT

Lena's savings are $34,000. After a six-month emergency reserve ($14,000) and planned obligations ($5,000), her **Risk Cap is $15,000**. Split: $1,500 validation, $1,500 iteration reserve, **$12,000 pilot-batch ceiling**.

Her planned 3,000-pouch run has a total exposure of $20,250, about **69% above her ceiling**. The conclusion is not "find more money." It is: the first order will be smaller than the plan, and it will be sized by evidence. Chapter 11 shows how.

Rules of the Risk Cap.

- Write it, date it, sign it. Show it to one person you trust.
- Raise it only **between** gates, deliberately. Never during a test and never after a good result.
- Do not fund it with money you need for rent, debt or emergencies. Borrowed money still has to be repaid if the product does not sell. This book does not advise on financing, and the worksheet is a planning aid, not financial advice.

OUTPUT FOR YOUR VALIDATION FILE

- ☐ **First-Order Exposure Table** completed with your own quote and an honest ad-spend assumption
- ☐ **Risk Cap** calculated, split into three buckets, signed and dated
- ☐ **Time cap** written down (total days, hours per week)
- ☐ The **bias** you are most likely to fall for, written in one line
- ☐ **Validation File** opened, with Section 00 filled

TOOL 1.1 · PRINT OR COPY INTO YOUR VALIDATION FILE

First-Order Exposure Table

Total money at risk before you know whether the product works. Use your own quote. The Kora column shows the format.

Cost item	Kora	Yours	Source or note
A · BEFORE PRODUCTION			
Recipe samples and rounds	$450		
Nutrition analysis and shelf-life check	$900		
Label and pack design	$600		
Product liability insurance, year one	$750		
Other: registration, permits, lab tests	$0		
B · PRODUCTION			
Production run: units × price per unit (your quote)	$4,200		
Primary packaging and labels (check packaging minimums)	$900		
Setup, tooling or plate fees	$0		
C · AFTER PRODUCTION			
Inbound freight and import costs	$350		
Storage for the sell-through period	$300		
D · LAUNCH ASSETS			
Website, photography, other launch assets	$800		
E · SELLING IT			
Customers needed = units ÷ units per customer	500		
Assumed cost to win one customer	$22		
Ad and outreach spend = customers × cost	$11,000		
TOTAL EXPOSURE	**$20,250**		
Revenue if everything sells (before shipping, fees, returns)	$12,000		
Quote ÷ total exposure	21%		
Total exposure ÷ your Pilot-Batch Ceiling (Tool 1.2)	169%		

If a line is unknown, write "?" and treat it as a research task. Unknown costs are the ones that surprise you after the order.

TOOL 1.2 · PRINT OR COPY INTO YOUR VALIDATION FILE

Risk Cap Worksheet

Decide the maximum you can lose, in advance. A planning aid, not financial advice.

Line	Item	Kora	Yours
1	Liquid savings today	$34,000	
2	Emergency reserve (for example six months of essential expenses)	– $14,000	
3	Planned obligations in the next 12 months (taxes, tuition, debt payments, other)	– $5,000	
4	Financing you would need to take on: not counted in the cap by default	$0	
5	**RISK CAP** = line 1 – line 2 – line 3	**$15,000**	
6	**Validation Budget**: 10% of the cap. Spent before any order, lost if you Kill	$1,500	
7	**Iteration Reserve**: 10% of the cap. For one retest if the verdict is Iterate	$1,500	
8	**Pilot-Batch Ceiling**: the rest. Maximum total exposure for production, packaging, freight, storage, launch assets and ads	$12,000	
9	Total exposure of your planned first order (Tool 1.1)	$20,250	
10	Does line 9 fit under line 8? If not, by how much does it exceed it?	No, by $8,250 (69%)	
11	**Time cap**: total days for validation	30 days	
12	**Time cap**: hours per week you can give it	10 hours	

If line 9 exceeds line 8: shrink the batch, stage production, or raise the cap deliberately, between gates. Do not hope the evidence will make the problem disappear.

I SET THIS CAP BEFORE TESTING AND WILL NOT RAISE IT DURING A TEST.

Signed	Date	Shown to (name)